ECON 124: World Economic History

Instructor: Xinran Liu
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Office Hours: Tuesday 9:00-11:00 AM and By Appointment (Zoom)
Class Meetings: MW 2:00-4:50PM at Olmsted 1136

Course Description

This course will explore world history from an economic perspective, meaning that it will focus more on the innovations and growth of civilizations as opposed to wars and conflicts. We will begin with ancient civilizations and the Paleolithic period and discuss how economics has shaped the rise and fall of these cultures. We will also discuss how the innovations and culture of civilizations throughout history have influenced present day economic organization

Course Objectives

By the end of the course, students are expected to be able to:

- Be familiar with the sources of economic progress as we understand them today and how the presence or absence of these sources of economic progress have contributed to the rise and fall of civilization throughout history, respectively.
- Understand the influences of major economic innovations and natural events throughout history in shaping the world and modern day life.
- Provide you a deeper understanding of various economic sub-disciplines and their respective areas of focus.
- Develop their writing and critical thinking skills

Course Materials

Required: Canvas (elearn.ucr.edu).

- This is where you will find all course materials (exams, assignments, lecture notes).

Recommended Textbooks:

- *More: A History of the World Economy from the Iron Age to the Information Age* by Philip Coggan. 2020.
- *How the World Became Rich: The Historical Origins of Economic Growth* by Mark Koyama and Jared Rubin. 1st Edition. 2022.
- *The Industrial Revolution: A Very Short Introduction* by Robert C. Allen. 1st Edition. 2017.
- *Global Economic History: A Very Short Introduction* by Robert C. Allen. 2011.

Lectures will be based off of these books, but no readings will be directly assigned from them.

Grading

Short Writing Assignments

Throughout the course, you will complete **three short writing assignments (SWA)**: three based on podcasts (60–80 minutes each) and one based on a short paper or film. Each SWA will include guiding questions that you must address in your response.

Requirements

- **Maximum length: 500 typed words for each question (strict limit).** Responses exceeding this limit will have points deducted (e.g., 5% off per 50 extra words).
- Submit electronically via **Canvas** by 11:59 PM on the due date.
- Late submissions will not be accepted unless prior instructor approval or documented emergency is provided.

Grading Criteria (20% of final grade)

1. **Clarity and Organization (30%)** – Logical flow with clear thesis and supporting points.
2. **Content and Understanding (40%)** – Addresses all guiding questions and demonstrates comprehension of the material.
3. **Critical Thinking (20%)** – Offers analysis, connections to course themes, and original insights.
4. **Mechanics (10%)** – Grammar, spelling, and proper formatting.

Tips

- Do not summarize the entire podcast or movie; focus on the guiding questions provided.
- Use examples from the material to support your points.
- Plagiarism, including use of AI tools to generate or edit assignments, is strictly prohibited and will be treated as academic misconduct.

Midterm Exam

The midterm exam will be taken in person. Late exams will not be accepted. Exam is closed book/closed note. There are no make-up exams under any circumstances. In the event of a missed midterm for any reason the weight of that midterm will be shifted to the final report. You **may not** work with anyone else on the exams. The midterm will take place during week 3 of the term.

Class Participation

Throughout the course, you will participate in **six in-class games** designed to illustrate key concepts in world economic history (e.g., trade, cooperation, resource allocation, financial crises). Each game is worth **2 points**, for a total of **12 points**.

- These points count toward your participation grade.
- Completing all six games will earn the full 12 points.
- An additional **2 points of extra credit** will be available through bonus questions or special activities during the games.
- Active participation in discussions and group work during these games is required to receive credit.

Presentation and Final Report

Each student will give a 15- 20 minute in-class presentation on the topic of *The History of Technological Anxiety and the Future of Economic Growth*. The presentation should connect historical cases of technological change with their economic impacts and discuss implications for future economic growth. Use slides or visual aids if appropriate.

After completing the presentation, submit an individual written report summarizing your analysis and insights. The report must not exceed **3000 words (including punctuation)** and is due one week after your presentation.

Report Format Requirements:

- Maximum 3000 words, including punctuation. Submissions exceeding this limit will incur a penalty.
- Typed, double-spaced, standard 12-point font (e.g., Times New Roman).
- Must be submitted in **PDF format**.
- Must include:
    1. Introduction (context and purpose)
    2. Main analysis (historical examples, economic impacts, future implications)
    3. Conclusion (summary and personal insights)
    4. References (if any; use consistent citation style)

Course Schedule and Tentative Due Dates:

	1st Lecture	2nd Lecture	Due date
Week 1	Course overview	The Ancient Economy & Game 1	07/31 SWA 1 due
Week 2	The Rise of Asia & Game 2	The Commercial Revolution & Game 3	08/07 SWA 2 due
Week 3	Malthus and Mercantilism & Game 4	Midterm	
Week 4	First Industrial Revolution & Game 5	The Great Recession & Game 6	08/21 SWA 3 due
Week 5	Presentation	Presentation	08/29 Final Report due

Assignment Weights:

Assignment	Weight
Participation	10%
Short Writing Assignments	15%
Midterm	25%
Presentation	20%
Final report	30%

Course Conduct

This class should be an environment that is free of bias, discrimination, and harassment. Please do your part to be kind and respectful to others in all communications and Zoom meetings. If you feel that you have been a victim of inappropriate behavior, feel free to speak with me or access the resources available to you on campus, http://titleix.ucr.edu/resources/resources.html.

Academic Integrity

As a student in this class, it is your responsibility to act with integrity and accountability. I expect that you will complete all exams and assignments in the manner in which they are intended and inform me of suspected acts of academic misconduct by your peers. By doing so, you will affirm the integrity and intellectual work of the University and the degree it represents. Should you choose to commit academic misconduct in this course, you will receive a failing grade. In all cases, you will be reported the Student Conduct and Academic Integrity Programs (SCAIP), and you will be held accountable according to the policies set forth by the University.

The use of artificial intelligence (AI) tools (such as ChatGPT or similar) to generate, edit, or complete any portion of your assignments or exams is strictly prohibited unless explicitly authorized by the instructor. Unauthorized use will be considered academic misconduct and treated accordingly.

For more information about the University's Academic Integrity policies, visit http://conduct.ucr.edu/policies/academicinte

Accommodations

Any student who needs accommodation should notify me as soon as possible to make these arrangements with the Student Disability Resource Center (SDRC).

Privacy Protection

Lecture materials and live and pre-recorded class-related materials that depict the images or voices of students are protected under the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA). It is a violation of federal law to share these materials with anyone outside of the classroom. In addition, all lecture and classroom materials are the sole intellectual property of the instructor. Any use or distribution of these materials requires the explicit written permission of the instructor.

I reserve the right to change any of this information due to unforeseen circumstances or to better meet the goals of the course.